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in higher footfalls and occupancy levels. With the theatre owners' share of collections (40-50 per cent) and expenses (power consumption and labour) being fixed for any film—hit or flop, Ramanathan says: "As a theatre owner, only if I get films like Rajini's can I survive. So, God knows, we will wait for Rajini's films."

"More than everybody making money on his films, nobody loses money. That's brand Rajinikanth," says Ruban Mathivanan of GK Cinemas, a two-screen theatre in Chennai. He says even when a Rajini film underperforms, the collection is on par with that of a second-rung actor, but is not at a loss for the exhibitor. In Tamil Nadu, tickets are not sold for more than ₹150-190 (excluding taxes) owing to a price cap. "If a film collects big money on the ₹190 ticket price, everybody gets a good profit—producer, distributor and exhibitor," says Mathivanan.

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It hasn't always been smooth sailing, especially for distributors. *Baba* (2002), produced and co-written by the superstar himself, bombed at the box office and the actor was forced to reimburse distributors. Similarly, *Kuselan*, *Lingaa*, *Kochadaiiyaan* and *Darbar* have proved to be losses for distributors in recent times, with *Kabali* earning them only meagre returns. Industry insiders point to producers overhyping the film and jacking up distribution rates, resulting in lower returns or loss for the distributors, though the film may have earned decent box office collections. For instance, *Lingaa* made on an estimated budget of ₹100 crore collected a reported ₹150 crore in worldwide gross. But the film's distributors faced losses and threatened protests, which culminated only with the actor paying them around ₹10 crore as compensation.

Even *Annaatthe*, also produced by Sun Pictures, was a flop. The film production arm of Sun TV Network first

AKSHAY KUMAR, SALMAN KHAN & SHAH RUKH KHAN PHOTOS BY MILIND SHELTE; ALLU ARJUN PHOTO BY BANDEEP SINGH; PRABHAS PHOTO BY KRISHNENDU HALDER; AAMIR KHAN PHOTO BY RACHIT GOSWAMI

SOURCE: INDUSTRY ESTIMATES